

CODIFYING REINCARNATION

the birth of spiritism

Like spiritualism (see pp.224–227), spiritism is based on the idea that people's spirits survive after death and can be contacted through mediums. One main difference between the two is that spiritism adds a belief in reincarnation. Today it is often viewed as a branch of spiritualism.

Codifying the spirits

The 19th-century French educator Hippolyte Léon Denizard Rivail, better known by his pen-name Allan Kardec, analyzed spiritualist ideas from around the world and organized them into the belief system that became known as spiritism, which combined elements from religion, philosophy, science, and nature. He wrote his “Spiritist Codification”—key works, including *The Spirits’ Book* (1857)—in the form of a kind of conversation with spirits.

Kardec shared with Christianity the concept of moral improvement. However, he also believed in reincarnation. He thought that spirits could be



◀ Kardec's creation

La Revue spirite was founded by Kardec in 1858 and became the principal French journal on spiritism and the study of spiritualistic matters. This 1931 edition of the quarterly publication bears a picture of Kardec on its front cover.

good and bad, and that all living things were immortal and they went through repeated incarnations on their journey to greater perfection. Kardec aimed to codify spiritualistic phenomena by applying rigorous, scientific-style

inquiry, based on observation

and experiment rather than theory. To him, spirits were simply a part of the natural world, acting according to natural laws, and therefore eligible for study just like any other facet of nature.

Caribbean connections

Spiritism spread across the world and was especially well received in the Caribbean and Latin America in the late 1800s and the 1900s. Variants emerged, including Santería/La Regla de Ocha, Espiritismo, and Macumba. Macumba developed in Brazil after Africans, enslaved by the Portuguese, arrived there, merging their animism (belief in spirits) with spiritism. The spiritism of ordinary, often rural, people in the Americas came to be allied with witchcraft and the occult by its detractors, and has frequently been denounced by the Christian Church.

In Brazil, forms of spiritist ideas, such as Umbanda and urban Quimbanda, developed, and spiritism merged with traditional folk religion and elements of Catholicism. Brazilian medium Zélio Fernandino de Moraes was a key figure of spiritism, seen as the founder of Umbanda. He formalized Umbanda into the Spiritist Union of Umbanda in 1939 and ran the organization until he died in 1975.

▼ Art magic

This illustration is from William Britten's *Art Magic, or, Mundane, Sub-mundane and Super-mundane Spiritism*, an 1870s work on spiritualism, spiritism, and theosophy that drew on spiritual practices from around the world such as the spinning rituals of these whirling dervishes.

